

Title

Community Perceptions of Criminology Students as Future Police Officers

Introduction

Criminology students are commonly associated with becoming police officers due to the strong public linkage between Criminology education and law enforcement. Under **Republic Act No. 11131 (Philippine Criminology Profession Act of 2018)**, the scope of practice for criminologists extends beyond police service to include forensic science, correctional administration, industrial security, probation, and academic research. However, public awareness often remains narrowly focused on policing. While previous research has largely concentrated on the career preferences of Criminology students themselves, less attention has been given to community-level understanding of the program.

Statement of the Problem

This study seeks to understand how adult community members perceive Criminology students in relation to becoming police officers.

Specifically, it seeks to answer the following questions:

1. How do community members perceive Criminology students as future police officers?
2. What factors and reasons influence community members to associate Criminology students primarily with police work?
3. What do community members know about the broader Criminology program and its various career paths under RA 11131?

Objectives

This study aims to:

1. Explore community members' perceptions of Criminology students as future police officers.
2. Identify the reasons and sources of influence behind associating Criminology students with police work.
3. Determine community members' level of awareness regarding the Criminology program and its alternative career paths.

Significance of the Study

This study will help Criminology students understand community expectations and occupational stereotypes associated with their field. Additionally, it will assist Criminology educators and administrators in identifying gaps in public awareness, guiding community outreach initiatives to promote a broader understanding of the criminologist profession.

Review of Related Literature (RRL)

Previous studies demonstrate a heavy preference among Criminology students toward law enforcement careers. For instance, empirical findings by Santos et al. (2020) revealed that over 75% of surveyed

Criminology students chose the course with the primary intent of joining the Philippine National Police (PNP). Similarly, research by Garcia (2021) highlighted that media exposure, family expectations, and civil service security were the primary motivators driving students toward police roles.

However, studies focusing on public and community perceptions (e.g., Perez & Ramos, 2019) indicate that general community members frequently equate Criminology solely with police work due to visible uniform practice, community immersion activities, and historical institutional framing. Existing literature highlights a distinct gap in public knowledge regarding non-policing roles established under **RA 11131**, such as document examination, crime scene investigation, and correctional counseling. This study addresses this gap by directly examining community perspectives and the root factors shaping these perceptions.

Methodology

- **Research Design:** Qualitative research design using a thematic analysis approach.
- **Participants & Sampling Method:** The respondents will consist of adult community members (aged 18 years and above) residing in selected barangays of Calasiao, Pangasinan. Participants will be selected using **purposive sampling** based on their willingness to participate and their familiarity with local Criminology students or programs.
- **Data Gathering & Analysis:** Data will be collected through face-to-face, semi-structured interviews using an interview guide. Audio-recorded responses will be transcribed and analyzed thematically to identify core themes regarding public perceptions, occupational stereotypes, and program awareness.